

Mengnan Xu

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PhD in Public Management (defense May 2026), Beijing Normal University

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Chinese politics and governance; state capacity and organizational mobilization; development governance; China's poverty alleviation programs; AI and computational methods for social science; political economy of China; South–South cooperation and international development.

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Public Management

Beijing Normal University, School of Social Development and Public Policy

Oct 2018 – May 2026

Beijing, China

Master of Public Management

Beijing Normal University, School of Social Development and Public Policy

Sep 2016 – Jun 2018

Beijing, China

Master of Science, Information Technology and Management

University of Texas at Austin, McCombs School of Business

Jul 2023 – May 2024

Austin, TX, USA

Concurrent with doctoral study at Beijing Normal University.

Bachelor of Management Science & Engineering (MIS)

Central South University

Sep 2008 – Jun 2012

Changsha, China

Doctoral Dissertation:

The Impact of Targeted Poverty Alleviation Policies on Long-Term Development and Vulnerability to Poverty Relapse Among Rural Households: Evidence from a Quasi-Natural Experiment Using CFPS Panel Data
Beijing Normal University, School of Social Development and Public Policy.

Passed blind external review; oral defense scheduled May 2026.

VISITING POSITIONS

Visiting Doctoral Researcher

Department of Government, University of Texas at Austin

China Scholarship Council Fellowship

Aug 2021 – Aug 2022

Austin, TX, USA

Visiting Scholar

University of Oxford

Sep – Oct 2019

Oxford, UK

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

China Scholarship Council (CSC) Fellowship for Visiting Doctoral Research, Department of Government, University of Texas at Austin. Aug 2021–Aug 2022.

STEPS Summer School Scholarship, Institute of Development Studies (IDS), University of Sussex. 2021.

Young Scholars Forum Scholarship, University of Hong Kong. Jul 2019.

PUBLICATIONS & WORKING PAPERS

Xu, Mengnan, Robert Walker, and Lichao Yang. “Poor and Lazy: Understanding Middle-Class Perceptions of Poverty in China.” *Journal of Contemporary China*, 31(136), 756–769, 2022. DOI: 10.1080/10670564.2021.2010878. (SSCI Q1; **First Author**)

Xiaoxin Xu, Xiulan Zhang, Teh Wei Hu, Leonard S Miller, **Xu, Mengnan** et al. “Tobacco Control Policy Evaluation in China: Evidence from Administrative Panel Data.” *BMJ Open*, 2019.

Xiulan Zhang, Xiaoxin Xu, **Xu, Mengnan**, and Teh-wei Hu. “The Impact of Tobacco Taxation Policy on Slim Cigarette Use and the Growing Popularity of Slim Cigarettes in China Since 2014.” *Health*, 2019.

Xiulan Zhang, **Xu, Mengnan**. “Organizational Ecology and Multi-Actor State Mobilization in China’s Poverty Alleviation Governance.” *Working paper. Original database complete; manuscript under revision; submission planned during postdoctoral fellowship.*

Xiulan Zhang, **Xu, Mengnan**. “Computational Methods for Large-Scale Chinese Policy Document Analysis: A Text-as-Data Approach to Governance Research.” *Working paper. Data collection and processing complete; writing in progress; submission planned during postdoctoral fellowship.*

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Postgraduate Research Assistant

Sep 2016 – Jun 2018

Beijing Normal University, School of Social Development and Public Policy

Beijing, China

Gates Foundation–Funded Research Initiative on Development Governance

- Built an original organizational ecology database tracking actors, resource flows, and governance logic across China’s non-profit sector, drawing on yearbooks, government reports, and policy documents.
- Applied NLP pipelines (topic modeling, named-entity recognition, keyword co-occurrence networks) to Chinese-language policy corpora exceeding 10,000 documents.
- Designed and executed large-scale quantitative and qualitative data collection; performed statistical analysis using SAS, Stata, and Python.
- Conducted archival research and comparative policy analysis on Chinese governance, central–local relations, and organizational reform.
- Translated empirical findings into policy briefs for program leadership and external stakeholders; coordinated across government, university, and foundation partners.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

“The Concern of Netizens towards Electronic Cigarette in Their Internet Search Behavior.” China–Korea Academic Exchange Forum (Beijing Normal University & Soongsil University), Beijing, China. October 2019. *First Prize; Best Presentation Award.*

“The Concern of Netizens towards Electronic Cigarette in Their Internet Search Behavior.” Annual Research Postgraduate Conference, University of Hong Kong, Hong Kong. June 2019.

“Consensus Guidance, Policy Advocacy Mechanism on China Tobacco Control.” China–Korea Academic Exchange Forum (Beijing Normal University & Soongsil University), Seoul, South Korea. May 2018.

RELEVANT PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Software Engineer / AI Engineer

Jun 2025 – Mar 2026

Apple Inc.

- Developed components for Apple’s Intelligence platform, focusing on production-scale natural language processing pipelines and retrieval-augmented generation architectures.
- Applied large language model techniques to large-scale information processing and knowledge integration systems, gaining first-hand engineering experience with the tools now central to computational social science.

Software Engineer

Apr 2026 – Present

Applied Optical Technologies

- Built full-pipeline automated data monitoring and analytics system for manufacturing execution processes.
- Designed modules for large-scale data collection, cleaning, and multi-dimensional statistical analysis.

Senior Risk Analyst

Jul 2012 – Jun 2016

Agricultural Bank of China

Hengyang, China

- Extracted and analyzed large-scale financial datasets using SQL and statistical modeling to support risk management and policy analytics.
- Developed credit scoring models (logistic regression, WOE binning) that reduced default rates and improved loan processing efficiency.

METHODOLOGICAL AND TECHNICAL SKILLS

Quantitative and Computational Methods: Regression analysis, difference-in-differences, network analysis, causal inference; Python (pandas, NumPy, scikit-learn), R, SQL, STATA/SAS.

AI and NLP for Social Science: Large language models (fine-tuning, retrieval-augmented generation, prompt engineering), topic modeling (LDA, BERTopic), named-entity recognition, text classification, word embeddings; LangChain, OpenAI API, Hugging Face, AI agentic engineering.

Data Infrastructure: AWS (S3, Lambda, SageMaker), BigQuery, MySQL, MongoDB; Git, Jupyter, Tableau, Power BI.

Research Methods: Archival and documentary analysis, qualitative case study, elite interviews, survey research.

LANGUAGES

Mandarin Chinese Native

English Proficient (academic writing, presentations, and publication)

REFERENCES

Available upon request.